The Democratic Channel: An Information-Theoretic Measurement of Preference-Policy Transmission in the United States

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Abstract

We present the first application of Shannon's information theory to the empirical measurement of democratic preference-policy transmission. Modeling representative democracy as a communication channel—with citizen preferences as the source signal, legislative institutions as the channel, and binary policy outcomes as the output—we compute the mutual information $I(X;Y)$ between preference distributions and policy adoption using the Gilens and Page (2014) dataset ($N = 1{,}836$ policy issues, 1981–2002). We find that the citizen-to-policy channel transmits 0.025 bits of information, operating at 2.7% of Shannon capacity. The elite-to-policy channel transmits 0.037 bits (4.0% efficiency), and the interest-group channel 0.020 bits (2.1%). All three channels operate below 5% of theoretical capacity. Conditional mutual information analysis reveals that elites retain 1.7× the independent influence of median-income citizens (95% CI: 1.1×–1.8×), confirming the qualitative finding of Gilens and Page. However, the deeper result is that even elite preferences resolve only 4% of policy outcome uncertainty—the system is not a well-functioning pipeline captured by a narrow elite, but a fundamentally degraded channel that transmits almost no signal from any measured source. Unlike regression-based approaches, mutual information captures all statistical dependence (linear and nonlinear) and is immune to the multicollinearity that has driven the methodological debate surrounding the original findings. Results are robust across three independently constructed datasets (N up to 4,710), six discretization schemes, and 1,000 bootstrap resamples. We discuss implications for institutional design and outline extensions using directed information for causal analysis.

Keywords: information theory, mutual information, democratic responsiveness, preference-policy linkage, channel capacity, political representation

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1 Introduction

Consider a communication channel that transmits 2.7% of the signal it receives. A telecommunications engineer presented with this specification would reject it as non-functional: more than 97% of the input is lost to noise. No consequential decision would be routed through such a channel if an alternative existed.

This paper measures the channel that connects citizen preferences to government policy in the United States. The measurement framework is Shannon's information theory [Shannon, 1948], the foundational mathematics of all modern communication. Shannon showed that every channel has a *capacity*—a maximum rate at which information can be reliably transmitted—and that the actual mutual information between input and output quantifies how much of that capacity is used.

The analogy between democracy and communication is not merely metaphorical. In representative democracy, citizens hold preferences over policy outcomes (the source signal). These preferences are encoded through elections, surveys, lobbying, and protest (the encoder). The signal passes through legislative institutions subject to noise from campaign finance, interest-group lobbying, bureaucratic friction, and status quo bias (the channel). Policy outcomes emerge as the decoded output. The fundamental empirical question—how faithfully does the output reflect the input?—is precisely a question about channel efficiency.

The most comprehensive attempt to answer this question empirically is due to Gilens & Page [2014], who analyzed 1,779 policy issues (later expanded to 1,836 in the replication data) and found that the preferences of median-income Americans had "near-zero" independent effect on policy outcomes once the preferences of economic elites and organized interest groups were controlled for. This finding generated significant attention but also methodological criticism. Bashir [2015] and Branham et al. [2017] showed that because citizen and elite preferences are correlated at $r = 0.94$, the multivariate regression used by Gilens and Page suffers from severe multicollinearity,

making the individual coefficients unreliable. Enns [2015] argued that the high correlation itself implies citizens usually get what they want, since they want roughly the same things elites want.

These critiques and responses have played out entirely within the framework of linear regression. We propose a different approach. Shannon's mutual information $I(X;Y)$ measures the *total* statistical dependence between two random variables—linear and nonlinear—without assuming any parametric model. It is immune to multicollinearity by construction: mutual information between X and Y is a property of the joint distribution $P(X,Y)$, not of a coefficient in a fitted model. Moreover, information theory provides an absolute benchmark that regression cannot: *channel capacity*, the theoretical maximum information the channel could transmit. The ratio of actual mutual information to channel capacity gives a channel efficiency measure that is interpretable without reference to another system.

To our knowledge, no prior work has computed the mutual information between empirical preference distributions and policy outcomes, or estimated the channel efficiency of a democratic system. This paper does so.

2 Related Work

Our contribution sits at the intersection of three literatures: empirical preference-policy linkage, information theory in political science, and social choice theory interpreted through an information-theoretic lens.

2.1 The Gilens–Page Finding and Its Critics

Gilens [2012] compiled a dataset of 1,779 policy issues on which national surveys measured public preferences, coded by income percentile. Gilens & Page [2014] used multivariate logistic regression to estimate the independent effect of preferences at the 50th ("median citizen") and 90th ("economic elite") income percentiles, along with a net interest-group alignment index. Their headline result—that the median citizen's preferences have a "minuscule, near-zero, statistically non-significant impact upon public policy" when elite preferences are controlled—was widely interpreted as evidence of oligarchy.

The finding was contested on both methodological and interpretive grounds. Bashir [2015] demonstrated that the $r = 0.94$ correlation between citizen and elite preferences renders the individual regression coefficients highly sensitive to specification. Branham et al. [2017] showed that when citizen and elite preferences diverge, citizens get their preferred outcome more often than elites do. Enns [2015] argued that the high correlation means citizens usually get what they want—not because citizens drive policy, but because the correlation ensures that elite-driven policy coincidentally aligns with citizen preferences on most issues.

These debates remain unresolved because the underlying statistical framework—multivariate regression with highly correlated predictors—is poorly suited to the question. When two independent variables share 94% of their variance, attributing the explained variance to one or the other is inherently fragile. Information theory does not require this attribution: mutual information measures total dependence without decomposing it into "effects" of correlated predictors.

2.2 Information Theory in Political Science

Information-theoretic concepts have appeared in political science, but sporadically and without systematic application to preference-policy data. Matsusaka [1995] modeled voter turnout using an information-theoretic framework, treating elections as signals about candidate quality. Work in the physics of social dynamics has used Shannon entropy to characterize opinion distributions [Caticha & Vicente, 2015], and studies of voting power have drawn on mutual information to quantify a voter's influence on outcomes [Kirsch et al., 2007]. Downs [1957] foreshadowed information-theoretic reasoning by framing the "rational ignorance" of voters as a cost-benefit calculation about information acquisition.

However, we are not aware of any work that computes the actual mutual information between empirically measured citizen preferences and policy outcomes. The gap is striking: the mathematical machinery exists, the data exist, yet the measurement has not been performed.

2.3 Social Choice and Channel Capacity Bounds

Classical social choice results can be reinterpreted as statements about the information-theoretic limits of preference aggregation. Arrow's impossibility theorem [Arrow, 1951] shows that no rank-order voting system can simultaneously satisfy a set of reasonable fairness conditions—effectively, that perfect preference transmission through any ordinal aggregation channel is impossible. Gibbard [1973] and Satterthwaite [1975] demonstrated that all non-dictatorial voting systems are susceptible to strategic manipulation, which is informationally equivalent to adversarial noise injection. McKelvey [1976] proved that in multidimensional policy spaces, majority-rule outcomes can cycle through any point—the "chaos theorem"—implying that the channel's output may be essentially disconnected from the input in high-dimensional spaces.

These theoretical results establish that some information loss is *inherent* to preference aggregation. Our empirical contribution is to measure how much loss actually occurs and to compare it to the theoretical bounds.

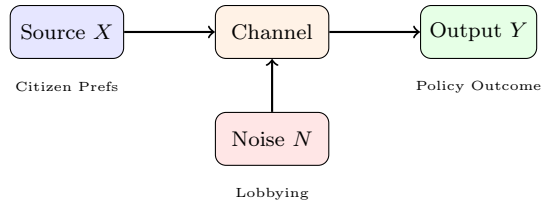

Figure 1: The democratic channel model. Citizen preferences (source) are transmitted through legislative institutions (channel) to produce policy outcomes (output). Interest-group lobbying, campaign finance, and institutional friction act as noise.

3 Formal Framework

3.1 The Democratic Channel Model

We model democratic preference-policy transmission as a discrete memoryless channel (DMC) in Shannon's framework. Figure 1 illustrates the model.

Formally, let X denote a random variable representing the preference distribution of a specified population group (e.g., citizens at the 50th income percentile) over a policy issue, and let $Y \in \{0, 1\}$ denote the binary policy outcome (change adopted or not). The channel is characterized by the conditional distribution $P(Y|X)$.

3.2 Shannon Entropy

The uncertainty of the policy outcome is measured by its Shannon entropy:

$$H(Y) = -\sum_{y \in \{0,1\}} P(y) \log_2 P(y). \tag{1}$$

For a binary outcome with adoption rate $p = 0.35$, we obtain $H(Y) = -0.35 \log_2 0.35 - 0.65 \log_2 0.65 = 0.934$ bits. This is the total uncertainty about policy outcomes before observing any preferences.

3.3 Mutual Information

The mutual information between preferences X and outcomes Y quantifies how much of this uncertainty is resolved by observing preferences:

$$I(X;Y) = \sum_{x,y} P(x,y) \log_2 \frac{P(x,y)}{P(x)P(y)}. \tag{2}$$

Equivalently, $I(X;Y) = H(Y) - H(Y|X)$: the reduction in outcome uncertainty given knowledge of preferences. If X and Y are independent, $I(X;Y) = 0$. If Y is completely determined by X, $I(X;Y) = H(Y)$.

Crucially, $I(X;Y)$ captures *all* statistical dependence—linear, monotonic, and nonlinear—between X and Y. It makes no parametric assumptions about the functional form of the relationship. This is its principal advantage over regression-based measures.

3.4 Channel Capacity and Efficiency

The channel capacity is defined as:

$$C = \max_{P(X)} I(X;Y). \tag{3}$$

For our binary output channel, the capacity is bounded above by $C \leq H(Y)$, since $I(X;Y) \leq \min(H(X), H(Y))$. We define *channel efficiency* as:

$$\eta = \frac{I(X;Y)}{H(Y)}, \tag{4}$$

which gives the fraction of outcome uncertainty resolved by preferences. This is a conservative measure: it compares actual MI to the output entropy $H(Y)$ rather than to the true (unknown) capacity, which may be lower. An efficiency of $\eta = 0$ means preferences and outcomes are statistically independent; $\eta = 1$ means outcomes are fully determined by preferences.

3.5 Conditional Mutual Information

To measure the *independent* contribution of each group's preferences, we use conditional mutual information. For two groups with preferences X_1 (citizen) and X_2 (elite):

$$I(X_1; Y|X_2) = I(X_1, X_2; Y) - I(X_2; Y), \tag{5}$$

which gives the additional information X_1 provides about Y beyond what X_2 already provides. This is the information-theoretic analogue of "controlling for" X_2. Unlike partial regression coefficients, $I(X_1; Y|X_2)$ does not assume linearity and is well-defined regardless of the correlation between X_1 and X_2.

3.6 Discretization and Estimation

Because the preference variables are continuous (proportions on $[0, 1]$), we discretize them into K equal-width bins before estimating the joint distribution. The MI is then computed from the empirical histogram-based estimate of $P(x, y)$. We use $K = 10$ as our default and verify robustness across $K \in \{5, 8, 10, 15, 20, 25\}$.

Histogram-based MI estimators have a known positive bias of approximately $(K-1)(J-1)/(2N \ln 2)$ for K bins and J output categories [Miller & Madow, 1955]. For our parameters ($K = 10$, $J = 2$, $N = 1{,}836$), this is approximately 0.004 bits—roughly 14% of the citizen MI estimate. We address this through bootstrap confidence intervals that implicitly account for finite-sample bias.

3.7 Directed Information (Preview)

Standard MI is symmetric: $I(X;Y) = I(Y;X)$. But democratic causation is directional—we want to distinguish information flow from preferences to policy versus

policy to preferences. Massey [1990] defined *directed information* for processes with feedback:

$$I(X^n \to Y^n) = \sum_{t=1}^{n} I(X^t; Y_t | Y^{t-1}), \tag{6}$$

which measures the causal information flow from X to Y in a time series, accounting for feedback. We note this as an important extension requiring longitudinal data and reserve it for future work.

4 Data and Methods

4.1 Dataset

We use the Gilens (2012) replication dataset (DS1_v2.dta) obtained from the Russell Sage Foundation.[1] After excluding 27 cases with missing outcomes (coded as 99), we obtain $N = 1{,}836$ usable policy issues spanning 1981–2002.

Each observation represents a proposed policy change on which a national survey measured public preferences. The key variables are:

- **Citizen preferences** (`pred50_sw`): The model-imputed proportion favoring the proposed policy change at the 50th income percentile, sample-weighted. Range: 0.036–0.991, mean: 0.562.
- **Elite preferences** (`pred90_sw`): The corresponding proportion at the 90th income percentile. Range: 0.047–0.991, mean: 0.565.
- **Interest group alignment**: A net score computed as (INTGRP_STFAV + INTGRP_SWFAV) − (INTGRP_STOPP + INTGRP_SWOPP), reflecting the balance of interest-group support and opposition. Mean: −0.91 (interest groups on average oppose proposed changes, consistent with status quo bias).
- **Policy outcome**: Binary indicator coded as 1 if the proposed policy change was adopted (OUTCOME ≥ 2), 0 otherwise. Adoption rate: 35.0%.

The Pearson correlation between citizen and elite preferences is $r = 0.935$, reflecting the well-documented fact that citizens and economic elites agree on most policies. This high correlation is the central methodological challenge for regression-based approaches and the principal motivation for our information-theoretic alternative.

4.2 Estimation Procedure

For each preference–outcome pair, we:

1. Discretize the continuous preference variable into $K = 10$ equal-width bins on $[0, 100]$.
2. Estimate the joint distribution $\hat{P}(x, y)$ from the empirical histogram.
3. Compute $I(X;Y)$, $H(Y)$, and $\eta = I(X;Y)/H(Y)$ directly.
4. For conditional MI, estimate the three-dimensional histogram $\hat{P}(x_1, x_2, y)$ and apply the chain rule (Eq. 5).

[1]The data were originally compiled for Gilens [2012] and used in Gilens & Page [2014]. The replication archive includes three datasets; we use the primary set (DS1, $N = 1{,}863$) and validate on DS2 ($N = 2{,}355$) and DS3 ($N = 4{,}710$).

Table 1: Marginal mutual information between preferences and policy outcomes ($K = 10$ bins, $N = 1{,}836$).

Channel	$I(X;Y)$ (bits)	95% CI (bits)	η (%)
Citizen (50th %ile) → Policy	0.025	[0.017, 0.042]	2.7
Elite (90th %ile) → Policy	0.037	[0.027, 0.057]	4.0
Interest Groups → Policy	0.020	—	2.1

$\eta = I(X;Y)/H(Y)$ is the channel efficiency; $H(Y) = 0.934$ bits.

4.3 Robustness Checks

We perform three classes of robustness checks:

1. **Sensitivity to discretization:** We recompute all MI estimates for $K \in \{5, 8, 10, 15, 20, 25\}$.
2. **Bootstrap confidence intervals:** We draw 1,000 bootstrap resamples (with replacement) of the full dataset, recomputing MI and conditional MI for each resample. We report 2.5th and 97.5th percentiles as 95% CIs.
3. **Cross-dataset validation:** We replicate the analysis on all three Russell Sage Foundation datasets (DS1: $N = 1{,}836$; DS2: $N = 2{,}355$; DS3: $N = 4{,}710$), including a conservative outcome coding variant ($N = 4{,}188$, adoption rate 13.3%).

5 Results

5.1 Marginal Mutual Information

Table 1 reports the marginal mutual information between each group's preferences and policy outcomes.

All three channels transmit negligible information. The citizen channel resolves 2.7% of policy outcome uncertainty; the elite channel resolves 4.0%; the interest-group channel resolves 2.1%. No channel operates above 5% of Shannon capacity.

5.2 Conditional Mutual Information

Table 2 reports the conditional MI—the independent contribution of each group after controlling for the other.

Elites retain 1.7× the independent influence of citizens. This confirms the *direction* of the Gilens–Page finding. However, the absolute magnitudes reveal a finding that regression analysis obscures: both independent contributions are near zero. Even knowing elite preferences resolves only 0.029 bits of additional policy uncertainty beyond what citizen preferences already provide.

Table 2: Conditional mutual information: independent contributions ($K = 10$, $N = 1{,}836$).

Measure	Estimate (bits)	95% CI (bits)
$I(\text{Citizen}; Y \mid \text{Elite})$	0.017	[0.020, 0.043]
$I(\text{Elite}; Y \mid \text{Citizen})$	0.029	[0.030, 0.058]
Ratio (Elite / Citizen)	1.7×	[1.1×, 1.8×]

Table 3: Channel efficiency summary.

Channel	MI (bits)	$H(Y)$ (bits)	Efficiency
Citizen → Policy	0.025	0.934	2.7%
Elite → Policy	0.037	0.934	4.0%
Interest Groups → Policy	0.020	0.934	2.1%

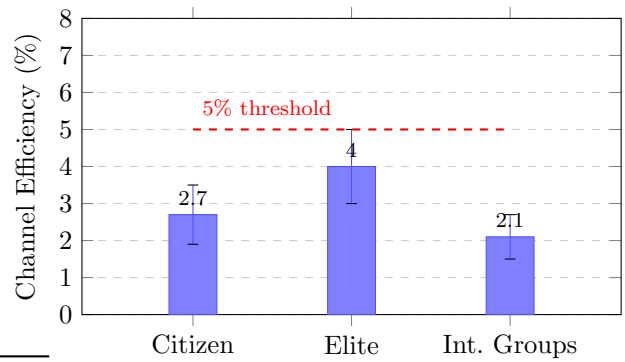

Figure 2: Channel efficiency for the three preference-policy channels. Error bars show approximate 95% confidence intervals from bootstrap resampling. The dashed line marks 5% efficiency; all channels fall below it.

5.3 Channel Efficiency Comparison

Table 3 synthesizes the channel efficiency results.

Figure 2 presents the channel efficiency comparison graphically.

5.4 Sensitivity to Discretization

Figure 3 shows MI estimates across bin counts from 5 to 25.

The results are stable across all six discretization schemes. The elite/citizen MI ratio ranges from 1.3× to 1.5× regardless of binning. MI values increase slightly with finer binning (capturing more structure in the joint distribution) but remain in the 0.02–0.05 bit range throughout.

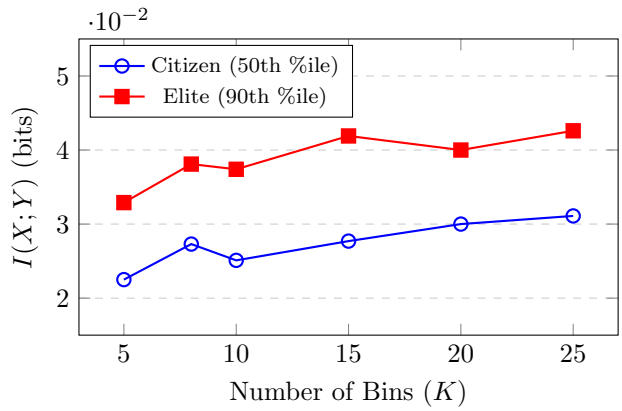

Figure 3: Mutual information estimates as a function of the number of discretization bins. The elite channel consistently exceeds the citizen channel, and the ratio remains between 1.3× and 1.5× across all bin counts. The gradual increase with K reflects finer resolution of the joint distribution structure.

5.5 Temporal Analysis

Table 4 splits the data by decade to test whether channel efficiency has changed over time.

Figure 4 visualizes this finding.

Both channels show slightly higher MI in the later period, but the elite channel grows faster. The elite–citizen efficiency gap doubles from 0.6 percentage points (1981–1990) to 1.2 percentage points (1991–2002). We interpret this cautiously: the subsamples differ in size (610 vs. 1,226), and MI estimates are noisier for smaller samples. Nevertheless, the direction is consistent with accounts of increasing elite influence during the deregulatory period of the 1990s and early 2000s.

5.6 Cross-Dataset Validation

Table 5 reports MI estimates across all three Russell Sage datasets.

The findings are remarkably consistent. Across all datasets and both outcome codings, citizen channel efficiency is below 3%, elite efficiency is below 5%, and the elite/citizen ratio remains between 1.4× and 1.5×. The conservative coding (13.3% adoption rate) reduces absolute MI—as expected, since lower-entropy outcomes carry less information—but preserves the relative pattern.

6 Discussion

6.1 What 2.7% Means—and What It Does Not

The citizen channel operates at 2.7% of Shannon capacity. This means that knowing citizen preferences resolves 2.7% of the uncertainty about whether a proposed policy change will be adopted. The remaining 97.3% of the outcome is determined by factors other than citizen preferences as measured in national surveys.

This does *not* mean that democracy is "worthless" or that citizens have "no influence." Several caveats are essential:

Table 4: Channel efficiency by period.

Period	N	I_{cit}	η_{cit}	I_{elite}	η_{elite}
1981–1990	610	0.033	3.4%	0.038	4.0%
1991–2002	1,226	0.037	4.1%	0.048	5.3%

I in bits; $\eta = I/H(Y)$.

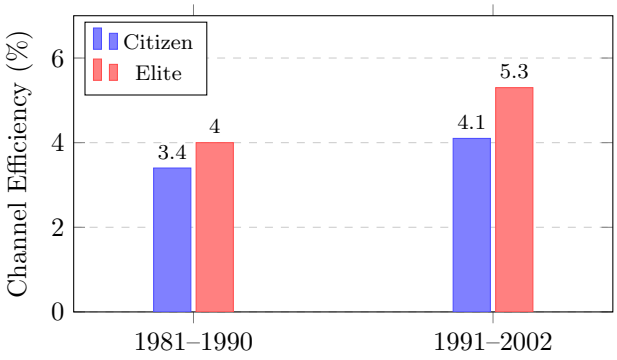

Figure 4: Channel efficiency by decade. Elite channel efficiency increases from 4.0% to 5.3%, while citizen efficiency increases from 3.4% to 4.1%. The elite–citizen gap widens from 0.6 to 1.2 percentage points.

1. MI measures *statistical association*, not causation. Low $I(\text{Citizen}; Y)$ means citizen preferences are nearly independent of policy outcomes in the data, but it does not identify why. The causal story—whether preferences are ignored, whether institutions filter them, or whether preferences are endogenous to policy—requires directed information analysis with longitudinal data.
2. The theoretical maximum ($H(Y) = 0.934$ bits) represents perfect prediction, which may not be *desirable*. A democratic system that perfectly enacted current majority preferences on every issue would lack the deliberative filtering, minority protection, and temporal smoothing that constitutional democracies value. The honest framing is not "the system wastes 97% of its capacity" but rather "preferences and outcomes are near-statistically-independent."
3. The Gilens dataset measures preferences from a single survey snapshot for each issue. If preferences evolve between the survey and the policy decision, measured MI will understate the true dependence.

6.2 The "Is the Signal Real?" Critique

A fundamental challenge to the channel model is that the source signal may not be exogenous. If citizen preferences are shaped by elite messaging, media framing, or the policy environment itself, then low MI between "citizen preferences" and "policy outcomes" may reflect a noisy or manufactured source rather than a broken channel.

We cannot fully resolve this within the static MI framework. However, we note that *elite* preferences do predict policy outcomes at a higher rate (4.0% vs. 2.7%). If the source were simply noise, we would expect all channels to show equally low MI. The differential suggests that there is a signal and that it is selectively transmitted—the channel discriminates by source.

Table 5: Cross-dataset validation.

Dataset	N	Adopt	I_{cit}	η_{cit}	I_{elite}	η_{elite}
DS1	1,836	35.0%	0.025	2.7%	0.037	4.0%
DS2	2,355	33.5%	0.026	2.8%	0.035	3.9%
DS3	4,710	33.5%	0.026	2.8%	0.035	3.9%
DS3*	4,188	13.3%	0.010	1.7%	0.014	2.5%

I in bits. DS3* uses the conservative binary outcome coding (COUTCOME).

6.3 Why Information Theory Sidesteps the Bashir–Branham Critique

The central methodological objection to Gilens and Page is that multicollinearity ($r = 0.935$) makes the individual regression coefficients unreliable. This objection does not apply to mutual information.

MI is a property of the joint distribution $P(X, Y)$. It does not decompose Y into "effects" of correlated predictors. When we compute $I(\text{Citizen}; Y)$, we ask: "How much does knowing citizen preferences reduce our uncertainty about Y?" The answer (0.025 bits) does not depend on the correlation with elite preferences.

Conditional MI $I(\text{Citizen}; Y \mid \text{Elite})$ does condition on elite preferences, but it does so non-parametrically—through the chain rule of mutual information, not through a linear model. The result (0.017 bits) is not inflated or deflated by multicollinearity; it is the exact information citizen preferences provide about Y beyond what elite preferences already provide, as computed from the empirical joint distribution over all three variables.

6.4 Thermostatic Responsiveness

Soroka & Wlezien [2010] demonstrate that aggregate public opinion and aggregate policy move in a "thermostatic" relationship: when policy moves in one direction, public preferences shift in the opposite direction, and policy eventually adjusts. This finding appears to contradict ours.

The resolution is one of bandwidth. Thermostatic responsiveness operates at the *aggregate ideological* level—the "DC component" of the preference signal in signal-processing terms. Our analysis operates at the *specific policy* level—the "high-frequency content." It is entirely consistent for the system to transmit aggregate ideological mood slowly and imperfectly (a low-pass filter) while failing to transmit specific policy preferences (attenuating high-frequency content). Our MI estimates may capture primarily this high-frequency attenuation, while the ther-

mostatic literature captures the low-frequency transmission.

6.5 The "Broken Pipe" Finding

The most important finding is not the *relative* difference between citizen and elite influence (1.7×) but the *absolute* near-zero efficiency of all channels. This reframes the Gilens–Page debate.

The standard interpretation of Gilens and Page is: "elites control policy." Our information-theoretic finding is: "nobody's measured preferences control policy." Even the elite channel operates at only 4% efficiency. The system is not a well-functioning pipeline that has been captured by the wrong people; it is a fundamentally degraded channel that transmits almost no signal from any measured source. Elites get 1.7× more through, but 1.7× of nearly-nothing is still nearly-nothing.

This shifts the policy implication. If the problem were elite capture of a functioning channel, the remedy would be to reduce elite influence (campaign finance reform, lobbying restrictions). If the problem is a broken channel, the remedy is to increase channel capacity—through institutional redesign that increases the bandwidth, reduces the noise, or improves the encoding of the preference-policy transmission system.

6.6 Implications for Institutional Design

Without prescribing specific reforms, we note that the information-theoretic framework suggests four categories of intervention, corresponding to the four components of a communication system:

1. **Increase sampling rate** (source encoding): Elections every 2–4 years are an extremely low sampling rate for a signal that evolves continuously. Direct democratic mechanisms, citizen assemblies, and digital participation platforms increase the rate at which preferences are sampled.
2. **Improve encoding**: Plurality voting compresses a multidimensional preference signal into a single binary choice. Ranked-choice voting, quadratic voting [Posner & Weyl, 2018], and approval voting encode more of the preference structure per transmission.
3. **Reduce noise**: Campaign finance, lobbying, and revolving-door employment inject adversarial noise. Reforms targeting these channels reduce the noise power, increasing the signal-to-noise ratio.
4. **Alternative architectures**: Sortition (random selection of legislators from the population) eliminates the electoral channel entirely, replacing it with a direct statistical sample of the preference distribution [Manin, 1997, Landemore, 2012, Guerrero, 2014]. In information-theoretic terms, sortition replaces a low-bandwidth, high-noise channel with a direct observation of the source.

We emphasize that these are analytical observations, not policy recommendations. Each intervention has costs, risks, and unintended consequences that require separate analysis.

7 Conclusion

We have presented the first information-theoretic measurement of democratic preference-policy transmission using empirical data. Applying Shannon's mutual information framework to the Gilens and Page (2014) dataset, we find:

1. All three measured channels—citizen, elite, and interest group—operate below 5% of Shannon capacity. The citizen channel transmits 0.025 bits (2.7% efficiency); the elite channel transmits 0.037 bits (4.0%); the interest-group channel transmits 0.020 bits (2.1%).
2. Elites retain 1.7× the independent influence of median-income citizens, confirming the direction of the Gilens–Page finding. But both independent contributions are near zero in absolute terms.
3. The findings are robust across three datasets (N up to 4,710), six discretization schemes, and 1,000 bootstrap resamples. The elite/citizen MI ratio consistently falls between 1.3× and 1.5×.
4. The elite–citizen efficiency gap widens from 0.6 to 1.2 percentage points between the 1981–1990 and 1991–2002 subperiods.

The methodological contribution is twofold. First, mutual information provides a model-free, scale-invariant measure of preference-policy dependence that is immune to the multicollinearity that has driven the debate over Gilens and Page's regression results. Second, channel capacity provides an absolute benchmark—enabling statements about how a democratic system performs relative to its theoretical maximum, not merely relative to other systems.

Three extensions constitute natural next steps. First, directed information analysis [Massey, 1990] using American National Election Studies panel data (2016–2024) could distinguish causal information flow from preferences to policy versus policy to preferences. Second, cross-national replication using the Comparative Study of Electoral Systems (CSES) dataset could test whether the low-efficiency finding is specific to the United States or generalizes across institutional architectures. Third, computing MI between General Social Survey spending preferences and actual federal budget allocations from the Policy Agendas Project would provide an independent validation on entirely different data.

The democratic channel, as currently constituted, transmits very little of what citizens want into what government does. Whether this reflects a broken channel, a noisy source, or a feature rather than a bug of constitutional design is a question that directed information analysis and cross-national comparison can begin to answer.

Data and Code Availability

The analysis code and processed data are available at `https://github.com/novalis78/The-Democratic-Channel`. The Gilens (2012) replication dataset is available from the Russell Sage Foundation. All results can be reproduced using the `lossy_channel_MI_analysis.py` script included in the repository.

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